Tensions and Opportunities: Accessing Embodied Experience in HCI through Micro-Phenomenology

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Abstract

Micro-phenomenology has recently gained traction in HCI as ways of accessing embodied, lived dimensions of interaction that resist conventional qualitative capture. By foregrounding pre-reflective experience, this approach promises greater experiential precision. However, when designers and HCI researchers attempt to apply Micro-phenomenology in practice, frictions often emerge. The method was not originally designed for design contexts, raising questions about accessibility, adaptability, and epistemic fit. We ask what is gained, transformed, or compromised when micro-phenomenology is brought into design research, and how they might evolve through situated practice. The workshop combines hands-on demonstrations of interviewing and analysis with guided reflective listening, followed by rotating small-group dialogues and material exploration. By bringing together researchers and practitioners interested in embodied and experiential approaches to HCI, the workshop aims to broaden access to micro-phenomenology while spurring critical dialogue about their limitations, transformations, and potential contributions to design research.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing → HCI theory, concepts and models**; **HCI design and evaluation methods**; **User studies**; **Interaction design process and methods**; **Interaction design theory, concepts and paradigms**.

Keywords

Micro-phenomenology; Embodied interaction; Lived experience; Design research; Reflective practice

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1 Background

Micro-phenomenology is a qualitative research approach designed to elicit and analyse lived experience [11, 12]. As interest in experiential inquiry has expanded, researchers have examined how micro-phenomenology translate into design research contexts. For example, Prpa et al. provided an early reflection on the state of applying micro-phenomenology in design research [14], while Heimann et al. later characterised the method as a powerful tool for studying user experience [3]. More recently, the approach has been discussed in relation to fourth-wave Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) and "entanglement" oriented perspectives [2, 4] to articulate relational qualities derived from human and more-than-human bodily encounters [10]. Together, these works signal an emerging effort to situate micro-phenomenology within broader HCI methodological discourse.

A review of HCI research over the past decade suggests that micro-phenomenology has been mobilised in two main ways. It has been used in a wide variety of contexts to investigate subjective and experiential phenomena in HCI, for instance in the design of vocal performance wearables [6, 16, 17], health and well-being [15], dancing and movement attunement [1], interaction with dynamic websites [3, 8], noticing processes [10], perception during earthquakes [9], tactile engagement with textiles [23], drone crashes [13], and encounters with interactive installations [19]. This growing body of work demonstrates both the methodological promise of micro-phenomenology and the diversity of contexts in which researchers seek to access fine-grained experiential detail.

However, micro-phenomenology and particularly its interviewing and analytic procedures, were not originally developed for HCI research. When these methods are adopted in design-oriented contexts, researchers frequently encounter methodological tensions. Broadly, these tensions can be understood as four interconnected barriers: linguistic, cultural, structural, and ethical.

Regarding the first linguistic barrier, formal training in micro-phenomenology is currently offered primarily in English, French, or Spanish, meaning that many researchers and participants are working in a second language. Yet micro-phenomenological interviewing depends on maintaining a precise state of evocation [11], requiring the interviewer to use subtle linguistic cues to guide participants toward fine-grained experiential recall. Limited language fluency can therefore compromise the depth and fidelity of elicited descriptions. Language structure and norms further complicate this process, especially when working with abstract references and the subtle nuances of emotional communication in a different languages. In high-context cultures, such as Chinese cultural contexts, communication often relies on implicit understanding, shared background knowledge, and situational cues rather than direct verbal articulation [7]. Within such communicative norms, direct prompts commonly used in micro-phenomenological interviews may sound unnatural or overly explicit. For example, a typical micro-phenomenological interview question like *"When you feel this, what do you feel?"*, which is designed to evoke synchronic depth to an experience, can appear contextually abrupt or linguistically redundant, potentially disrupting the participant's engagement with the evoked experience.[1]

Secondly, from a cultural and developmental perspective, individuals may not have grown up in environments that supported or encouraged the articulation of bodily or emotional experience. Research in somaesthetics design and soma design suggests that the capacity to attend to, conceptualise, and verbalise subtle bodily feelings is not self-evident, but often cultivated through practice and social norms [5, 20]. When such reflective practices are unfamiliar, participants may struggle to find vocabulary or conceptual framing for their lived bodily experience. This can, in turn, constrain engagement in the reflective stance that micro-phenomenological inquiry relies upon.

Thirdly, the integration of micro-phenomenology into HCI research varies in fit. The analytical framework of micro-phenomenology is designed to rigorously identify the fine-grained structure of lived experience. In doing so, so called satellite dimensions [11], such as reflective commentary or contextual information offered by the interviewee, are often set aside to maintain experiential precision. While methodologically coherent, this exclusion can be limiting in HCI contexts where such dimensions may be integral to understanding interaction and design implications. As a result, some researchers selectively adopt micro-phenomenological interviewing while deliberately departing from its formal analytic procedures [10]. Micro-phenomenological analysis also seeks to articulate both diachronic and synchronic structures of experience, tracing how experiential elements unfold over time and interrelate in the moment. This structured approach aligns well with HCI studies examining relatively bounded or sequential interactions [3, 23]. However, many embodied experiences emerge spontaneously, diffusely, or only become noticeable retrospectively. In such cases, establishing a stable diachronic structure can be challenging, complicating analysis and raising questions about how the method can accommodate less linear forms of experience.

Lastly, from an ethical perspective, the often intense experience of being interviewed warrants careful consideration. Micro-phenomenological interviewing emerged from a psychological research context and is designed to guide participants into a vivid evocation of lived experience [22]. This depth can make interviews particularly powerful and affectively resonant for both interviewer and interviewee, which in turn raises ethical concerns when personal or intimate material surfaces. The intensity of recall, combined with the interviewer's active guidance, requires careful attention to consent, emotional safety, and boundaries. In some cases, HCI researchers may not be prepared to handle issues arising from interviews, even when trained in micro-phenomenology. Formal training requirements partly address these concerns by equipping practitioners with interviewing skills and ethical awareness.

These tensions make it valuable to bring together researchers and practitioners to exchange perspectives and collectively examine how micro-phenomenology can be adapted within HCI research. Rather than treating these challenges as obstacles to be avoided, this workshop positions them as productive sites for reflection, experimentation, and methodological development.

In this workshop, we ask:

- **What changes when micro-phenomenology is translated into HCI contexts?**
- **How can linguistic, cultural, structural, and ethical barriers be addressed without diluting the experiential precision that defines the approach?**
- **What forms of adaptation are necessary to support diverse research settings, participants, and embodied phenomena?**
- **How might these negotiations reshape both the method itself and its role within HCI?**

By foregrounding these questions, the workshop aims to foster critical dialogue, shared learning, and practical exploration. Through demonstrations, guided exercises, and collective discussion, participants will examine real tensions encountered in practice and consider strategies for responsible and context-sensitive adaptation. The broader goal is to support a growing community of researchers committed to advancing embodied and experiential inquiry in HCI while maintaining methodological care and rigour.

2 Workshop Goals, Theme, and Outcomes

2.1 Workshop Goals

The workshop has three interrelated goals that address methodological learning, critical reflection, and community building within embodied interaction research:

First, the workshop aims to **introduce participants to the principles and practical applications of micro-phenomenological interview and analysis** as methods for accessing embodied experience. Through guided demonstrations and hands-on exercises,

[1] This, for instance, is an experience shared by authors Sun and Tian in being interviewed and training in micro-phenomenology.

participants will learn how to attend to the lived, pre-reflective dimensions of interaction and how to elicit detailed experiential descriptions. This goal emphasises the development of methodological sensitivity and confidence in working with embodied phenomena that are often difficult to articulate using conventional qualitative approaches.

Second, the workshop seeks to **foster critical reflection on how micro-phenomenology can be adapted for HCI research without compromising experiential precision**. Participants will examine the tensions that arise when translating a rigorously structured phenomenological inquiry into the iterative and situated contexts of HCI practice. This includes discussing practical constraints, ethical considerations, and opportunities for methodological innovation, encouraging participants to think carefully about how experiential inquiry can inform design processes.

Third, the workshop aims to **cultivate a community among researchers and practitioners interested in micro-phenomenological inquiries to HCI.** By creating a shared space for dialogue, experimentation, and reflection, the workshop supports the emergence of common methodological language and interests. This goal extends beyond the event itself, laying the groundwork for continued exchange, collaboration, and collective development of experiential methods within the HCI community.

2.2 Workshop Theme

This workshop is organised around four interconnected themes, introduced above, that reflect recurring barriers encountered when adapting micro-phenomenology for HCI research: linguistic, cultural, structural, and ethical barriers identified above. These themes emerge from the organisers' practical experience applying micro-phenomenology in design contexts and from ongoing discussions about how the method travels beyond its original disciplinary setting. Rather than treating these barriers as limitations, we approach them as productive tensions that can inform methodological refinement and contextual adaptation within HCI.

The first theme focuses on **linguistic translation and evocation**. Micro-phenomenological interview relies on subtle linguistic guidance to sustain a participant's state of evocation. When interviewer and participant operate in a second language, or within communicative norms that favour implicit rather than explicit articulation, this process may shift in unexpected ways. Participants will examine how interview prompts, pacing, and linguistic framing might be adapted across languages without compromising experiential precision.

The second theme addresses **cultural and developmental conditions of articulation**. The capacity to attend to and verbalise bodily experience is not universal but socially cultivated. In contexts where reflective engagement with emotion or bodily sensation is less commonly encouraged, participants may struggle to adopt the reflective stance that micro-phenomenological inquiry presupposes. This theme invites discussion of how preparatory practices, scaffolding strategies, or hybrid methods might support more inclusive participation.

The third theme explores **structural and epistemic alignment with HCI research**. Micro-phenomenological analysis privileges fine-grained experiential structures and often brackets contextual or interpretive dimensions. While this supports analytical rigour, it may sit uneasily with HCI research agendas that foreground situated use, meaning-making, or design implications. Participants will critically examine when to adhere to formal analytic procedures, when to adapt them, and how such adaptations affect methodological claims.

The fourth theme centres on **ethical intensity and researcher responsibility**. Because micro-phenomenological interview can evoke vivid and emotionally charged experiences, careful ethical consideration is essential. At the same time, uneven access to training and varying institutional contexts shape how responsibility is enacted in practice. This theme creates space to reflect on consent, care, boundaries, and preparedness when applying psychologically grounded methods in design research settings.

By structuring discussion around these four themes, the workshop creates a platform for collectively exploring how micro-phenomenology can evolve within HCI. Participants are invited to examine points of friction, propose adaptations, and reflect on how accessibility, responsibility, and methodological integrity can be balanced in embodied design research.

2.3 Anticipated Outcomes

The workshop will generate practical strategies for adapting micro-phenomenology in HCI, produce a community authored manifesto articulating its role in embodied design research, and establish an ongoing network to support collaboration and continued methodological development.

• ***Practical insights for adapting micro-phenomenology in HCI:*** Through hands on practice and structured discussion, participants will generate shared insights into how micro-phenomenological interviewing and analysis can be adapted for design oriented HCI contexts. These insights will address practical constraints, ethical considerations, and methodological tensions, helping clarify when and how the approach can be used to access embodied experience in research and design.

• ***Micro-phenomenology in HCI manifesto:*** Participants will collaboratively articulate a set of guiding principles that capture emerging perspectives on the role of micro-phenomenology in HCI research. The micro-phenomenology in HCI manifesto developed during the workshop will be documented, edited, and circulated after the event as a community authored artefact. Immediately following the workshop, organisers will synthesise participants' contributions into a draft document that preserves the core themes, tensions, and guiding principles articulated during the collective session. This draft will be shared with all participants for feedback and revision to ensure that it accurately reflects the diversity of perspectives expressed.

Once finalised, the manifesto will be published as an open access document through appropriate community channels, such as a workshop website or institutional repository, to support broad visibility and reuse. The organisers will also explore opportunities to develop the manifesto into a short position piece or collaborative publication aimed at HCI and design research audiences. This process is intended not only to disseminate workshop outcomes, but to sustain dialogue around adapting micro-phenomenology and to encourage continued experimentation and collaboration within the community.

• ***Potential collaborations and next steps:*** The workshop will serve as a foundation for building an emerging network for micro-phenomenology in HCI that connects researchers and practitioners interested in embodied and experiential inquiry. This network is intended to support ongoing exchange of methods, case studies, and practical adaptations, helping participants continue developing their work beyond the workshop.

Organisers will facilitate post workshop communication through shared mailing lists or online spaces, enabling participants to circulate resources, discuss methodological challenges, and explore opportunities for collaboration. Potential next steps include joint publications, follow up workshops, and collaborative research initiatives that advance the responsible integration of micro-phenomenology within HCI. The goal is to sustain a community of practice that encourages experimentation, critical reflection, and mutual learning.

3 Organisers

All members of the organising team have received formal training in micro-phenomenology and have applied this inquiry approach in HCI research context. Over the past year, the team has met regularly to explore how micro-phenomenology can be made more accessible and usable within the HCI community, with a focus on adapting the approach for design research while maintaining methodological rigour.

Xinglin Sun is a PhD candidate at the College of Design and Innovation, Tongji University, China. Her research investigates how embodied design can support women's mental wellbeing, with recent work examining how embodied practices facilitate stress related self-disclosure among adolescent girls [21]. As part of her doctoral project, she has worked with women in embodied embroidery practices and conducted micro-phenomenological interviews to study their lived bodily experiences.

Yulin Tian is a Postdoctoral Researcher at the College of Design and Innovation, Tongji University, China. Her work spans embodied interaction, digital health, and technology-mediated intimacy. Grounded in lived bodily experience, she explores how game-based rehabilitation, self-tracking with wearable health technology, and cross-dimensional intimacy with virtual characters become sites for rethinking human–technology relations.

Claudia Núñez-Pacheco is a Senior Lecturer at the Department of Computer Science and Media Technology at Malmö University in Sweden. Her research investigates bodily ways of knowing and language as materials for aesthetic experiences in design. She employs introspective and somatic practices to explore aesthetic and generative qualities in our interactions with technology. http://claudianunezpacheco.com

Bruna Petreca is a Reader in Human Experience and Materials at the Centre for Materials Science and Culture, Royal College of Art, in London, UK. Her work focuses on integrating human experience into emerging areas of materials development, including the circular economy, digital environments, distributed manufacture, and human health and wellbeing. Bruna has over a decade of experience with micro-phenomenology. She pioneered its application in textiles and design, and continues to advocate for its wider adoption across HCI, art, and design research.

Mirjana Prpa is an Assistant Professor at the Computational Media and Arts, Hong Kong University of Science and Technology (Guangzhou), China. Mirjana's research interests include understanding the complexity of user experiences by leveraging micro-phenomenology in HCI and design research [14] and its application to unfolding the complexity of experiences arising from human-AI interactions.

Courtney N. Reed is a Lecturer (Assistant Professor) in Digital Technologies and Creative Futures at Loughborough University London, UK. Her work explores vocalist-voice relationships [16] and how technoscientific and music pedagogical values shape the design and use of digital musical instruments. She has five years of experience working with micro-phenomenology to explore collaboration with technology in music performance [17, 18].

>Anton Poikolainen Rosén is an Assistant Professor at the Department of Computer and Systems Sciences, Stockholm University, Sweden. He has used micro-phenomenological interviews to articulate experiences of the more-than-human world [10] to inform the design of technologies that are more in tune with our experiences of ecological entanglements.

Ekaterina R. Stepanova is a Postdoctoral Research Fellow at the KTH Royal Institue of Technology supported by Banting Fellowship. Her work applies soma-design to design of immersive art installations aiming to support connection to one's self, others, and the world around them. With a background in Cognitive Science, she centres her work in approaches rooted in enactive cognition, incl. a trainning in micro-phenomenology, which she applies as a method for evocation of experience to unpack the complex emotional experiences, which are often tacit and embodied.

Laia Turmo Vidal is a postdoc at KTH Royal Institute of Technology, Sweden. Her current research combines touch technologies, first and second person design methods, and research through design to address highly personal and sensitive contexts, such as self-body perception and lived experiences of health.

4 Workshop Plan

4.1 Schedule

We propose a full-day workshop structured to balance methodological introduction, hands-on practice, and collective reflection. The day is organised into sequential sessions that progressively move participants from orientation to experiential engagement with micro-phenomenological interviewing and analysis, and finally to critical discussion and synthesis. This structure is designed to support both skill development and dialogue, allowing participants to directly experience the method while reflecting on its relevance, limitations, and potential applications in embodied HCI research.

Activity 1 - Opening and introductions (9:00-10:00). Organisers begin with a short introductory session outlining the goals and structure of the workshop and situating micro-phenomenology within embodied HCI research. To ground participants in experiential engagement from the outset, the session includes a guided body scanning exercise. This practice invites participants to gently attend to their present bodily sensations, cultivating awareness of subtle shifts in posture, breathing, and attention.

The session then transitions into a brief ice-breaking round in which organisers and participants introduce themselves and share their interests, experiences, or questions related to micro-phenomenology. Beginning with embodied attention establishes a shared experiential baseline and sets expectations for reflective, collaborative, and practice-oriented work throughout the workshop.

Activity 2 - Micro-phenomenological interview exercise and reflective listening (10:00-11:00). Organisers begin by demonstrating a short micro-phenomenological interview, highlighting key principles such as guiding participants into a specific experiential moment, maintaining a state of evocation, and using precise attentional prompts rather than interpretive questions.

For the hands-on exercise, participants are invited to work with a simple, concrete experiential protocol to ensure accessibility and comparability across groups. For example, one protocol involves vividly imagining biting into a lemon and attending to the unfolding sensory experience. Another involves physically placing the left hand over the right hand and slowly noticing the tactile, proprioceptive, and affective qualities of this contact. These scenarios provide bounded yet rich experiential events that can be revisited and explored in detail.

Participants then engage in guided interviews in small groups, rotating roles as interviewer, interviewee, and observer. Interviewers practice anchoring the experience in a specific moment, supporting sensory evocation, and following diachronic unfolding, while avoiding leading or interpretive prompts. Observers attend to linguistic cues, pacing, and moments where evocation deepens or weakens.

A brief plenary reflection concludes the session, allowing participants to share observations about the challenges of maintaining evocation, the difficulty of describing subtle bodily experience, and the methodological decisions made during the exercise. This activity enables participants to directly encounter how lived experience can be accessed, stabilised, and articulated through structured micro-phenomenological dialogue.

Activity 3 - Micro-phenomenological analysis demonstration (11:00-12:00). Following the interview practice, organisers introduce the core principles of micro-phenomenological analysis using excerpts from example interviews. The session begins with an overview of two central analytical concepts: diachronic structure and synchronic structure. Diachronic analysis traces how an experience unfolds over time, identifying sequential phases and transitions. Synchronic analysis, in contrast, examines how different experiential dimensions (sensory, attentional, affective, kinaesthetic) are organised and interrelated at a given moment. Together, these dimensions allow researchers to articulate the fine-grained architecture of lived experience.

Participants collaboratively examine selected interview excerpts and practice identifying experiential units, shifts in attention, and structural patterns. Organisers demonstrate how so-called satellite dimensions are distinguished from core experiential descriptions and discuss methodological decisions involved in constructing analytic diagrams or summaries.

To situate the analysis within HCI research, we share and briefly discuss examples of published work that have applied micro-phenomenological analysis in design contexts, including *FabTouch: A Tool to Enable Communication and Design of Tactile and Affective Fabric Experiences* [23] and *Micro-Phenomenology as a Method for Studying User Experience in Human-Computer Interaction* [3]. These cases illustrate how diachronic and synchronic structures have been mobilised to inform design reasoning, material exploration, and the study of user experience.

By connecting hands-on analysis to concrete HCI applications, this activity clarifies both the methodological rigour of micro-phenomenological analysis and the interpretive choices involved when translating experiential structures into design knowledge.

Activity 4 - Structured group dialogue and material reflection (13:30-15:30). After lunch, the workshop shifts to a structured and dynamic group process designed to deepen critical exchange. Rather than a single extended discussion, we organise a facilitated World Café–style rotation. Participants are divided into small groups, each hosted by one organiser, and rotate across thematic tables corresponding to the four identified barriers: linguistic, cultural, structural, and ethical.

At each table, participants engage with a focused guiding question, for example:

- What adaptations have you made when conducting interviews across languages or cultural contexts?
- When does micro-phenomenological analysis support design insight, and when does it constrain it?
- How do you navigate emotional intensity and ethical responsibility in practice?

Participants' submitted materials documenting their embodied research serve as shared reference points during these exchanges. Each round builds on the previous one, with table hosts briefly synthesising earlier contributions before new participants join.

To encourage embodied and non-verbal modes of reflection, the final round invites groups to represent their discussion through collage-making or diagrammatic mapping using provided materials. These visual artefacts externalise tensions, adaptations, and emerging principles, making abstract methodological questions tangible and discussable.

The session concludes with a plenary walkthrough in which each table shares key insights and unresolved questions. This structured yet creative format supports both depth and dynamism, while foregrounding collective sense-making about how micro-phenomenological methods can be responsibly adapted within HCI.

Activity 5 - Micro-phenomenology in HCI manifesto and wrap up (15:30-17:00). The workshop concludes with a collective synthesis session focused on articulating how micro-phenomenology can meaningfully contribute to HCI research and practice. Participants work together to distil key insights, tensions, and aspirations into a set of shared statements or guiding principles. This process emphasises accessibility, responsible adaptation, and future experimentation, reinforcing the workshop's aim of broadening engagement with the method while sustaining critical reflection on its evolving role in design research. The session closes with reflections on next steps and opportunities for continued collaboration.

4.2 Audience and Promotion

We welcome participants working with interactive systems in which bodily sensation, affect, and lived temporality play a central role, and who are seeking methodological approaches that move beyond representational, behavioural, or purely cognitive accounts of interaction. The workshop is open to both participants with prior experience in micro-phenomenology and those interested in incorporating these approaches into their research. To support participant preparation and ensure alignment with the workshop's experiential focus, we use a structured pre-workshop submission in the form of a Google Form. Rather than asking for a standalone position paper or creative artefact, the form invites participants to provide a set of concise reflective inputs, including: (1) how the workshop topic relates to their current or past research or practice, (2) any prior experience with micro-phenomenological methods, (3) a brief description of a situated bodily experience in interaction with technology, and (4) an optional material related to their work. These submissions are not treated merely as background information, but are actively integrated into the workshop activities. In particular, participants' descriptions of bodily experience serve as prompts for guided micro-phenomenological interviews and pair-based elicitation exercises. The information on participants' research contexts and submitted materials is used to support the formation of small groups and to anchor discussions in concrete practices.The workshop will be promoted through organisers' professional networks, social media channels (such as CHI Meta on Facebook - 5.2K members), and relevant mailing lists in HCI, design research (such as PhD-Design), and embodied interaction communities.

4.3 Venue

The workshop does not require specialised technical infrastructure. We request a comfortable, quiet meeting space that supports small-group interaction and discussion, ideally equipped with a projector for brief demonstrations. Movable chairs and tables are preferred to allow flexible group arrangements. Because the workshop involves reflective and experience-centred activities, it is important that the environment feels safe, welcoming, and conducive to open conversation.

4.4 Ethical Considerations

Given the affectively resonant nature of micro-phenomenological interviewing, we incorporate a set of explicit ethical safeguarding measures throughout the workshop. While such methods can support rich access to lived experience, they may also surface personal or emotionally charged material. Our design therefore includes both preventative and responsive strategies to support participant well-being.

First, at the beginning of the workshop, we establish clear expectations around participation, including the voluntary nature of all activities, the option to pause or withdraw at any time, and an emphasis on sharing only what participants feel comfortable disclosing. This is reinforced through a brief framing of care-oriented interviewing practices.

Second, we provide lightweight guidance to participants engaging in pair-based interviews, focusing on recognising signs of discomfort (e.g., hesitation, withdrawal, changes in tone) and responding appropriately. Suggested responses include slowing down the inquiry, shifting to less probing questions, or offering to pause or stop the interaction. Facilitators remain present during these activities to monitor dynamics and intervene if needed.

Finally, the workshop concludes with a guided debrief, where participants are invited to reflect on their experience of the methods as well as their emotional responses. We also provide information about follow-up contact with the organisers should any concerns arise after the workshop.

Together, these measures aim to translate ethical awareness into situated practice, ensuring that participants are supported throughout both the experiential and reflective components of the workshop.

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